

Using Digital Tools to Bridge the Distance Divide

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This talk introduced the qualitative research design behind my PhD study into music teachers' perceptions of creativity in China, presented to fellow doctoral researchers as part of a University of Glasgow PhD-led webinar series.

The study combined three rounds of semi-structured interviews with 24 classroom observations, conducted with three school music specialists and three piano teachers working with primary-school pupils, alongside critical-incident charting and a researcher diary to track my own developing interpretations over the course of fieldwork. Data were analysed thematically in NVivo, combining deductive coding — drawing on established theoretical frameworks — with inductive coding, which let themes emerge directly from the data.

Presented early in the project, the talk covered two things: the research design — in particular, how interviews and observation were combined and sequenced across fieldwork — and, at my supervisor's invitation, how COVID-19 had affected data collection. Fieldwork was based in China throughout, and I happened to already be there, on a break, when travel restrictions were introduced; my supervisor, by contrast, remained in Glasgow. The disruption this created was mainly to supervision rather than to fieldwork access itself — I adjusted the timing of data collection but was able to carry it out largely as planned. I described this situation and discussed the issues it raised, rather than presenting findings, which were still being developed at that stage.

Note: for how this fieldwork went on to generate an original model of creativity development, see Ge, X., Odena, O., & Livingston, K. (2026). *Teachers' Perceptions of Creativity: A Practice-Informed Model from Primary School Music and Piano Teaching in China*. Research Studies in Music Education. doi.org/10.1177/1321103X261460254.